

Asia Quantitative Strategy

Asia Quant Strategy: The rising dominance of Taiwan equities - Are we at an inflection point?



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The strong rally since last year has resulted in Taiwan becoming the biggest exposure in MSCI EM Index (~25%) and MSCI Asia ex Japan Index (28%). The comfort so far had come from the fact that the rally was driven more by earnings vs. multiple expansion. However, we believe we are close to an inflection point as the mounting risk from record high earnings expectations, all-time high valuations, peak concentration risk and decade high dispersion cannot be ignored. We recommend reducing exposure towards high momentum and high growth stocks in Taiwan.

Taiwan is now the most dominant exposure in the regional benchmarks and funds:

As of April end 2026, Taiwan is the biggest exposure in MSCI EM and MSCI Asia ex Japan benchmarks, accounting for ~25%/28% of the index. GEM funds, on an average have 22.3% allocation in TW, 20% in China, 17% in KR and 10% in India. Since April, TW has seen the highest foreign flow (+16bn USD) in Asia, outside Japan, and it is already at record high monthly flow, creating strong case for near-term reversal.

Strong fundamentals but isn't it all priced-in?: Fundamentally the market looks quite strong with high ROIC (11.5%), high innovation and the strongest growth exposure in Asia (3yr earnings growth expectations of 29% CAGR). While the robust earnings upgrade cycle has supported the market rally so far, the bullish expectations are now near historical high, raising risk of upgrade cycle peaking. The valuations have already been quite stretched - market is at record high multiple of 21x fwd. PE and 4.5x PB while the equity risk premium is at record low levels.

The tech sector at record high valuations & earnings: In our earlier note, we highlighted how the [strong momentum in Taiwan and Korea is facing record high concentration and correlation risk](#). Taiwan's top 5/10 names account for 66%/72% of the market cap while Semis and Tech Hardware, account for 84% of the market cap. Both Semis (35x fwd. PE) and Tech Hardware (26x fwd. PE) are trading at record high valuations and even upward revisions for Tech Hardware has reached record high. While for Semis, there is still some room for upgrades to continue, the bullish sentiment is not too far from record high.

The melt-up in growth and momentum stocks is at high risk of inflection: Growth and momentum stocks have ripped up YTD, generating 60% to 70% alpha (up more than 100% on an absolute basis). Taiwan high momentum portfolio is now trading at record high valuations, compared to its own history and relative to market while the earnings upgrades have also reached record high levels. Growth stocks, are also quite stretched, though still shy of 2020/2024 peak valuations; however bullish expectations are already at all-time high. While the crowding in growth stocks is already at record high, for momentum the crowding risk is lower. Even quality stocks in Taiwan (which have generated 15% alpha YTD) are trading at all-time valuations and earnings. The extreme momentum has created a 10year high dispersion between growth and value, with value dropping to record high bearish sentiment. We find these factor moves unsustainable and recommend reducing exposure towards momentum/growth stocks. **We show the most vulnerable stocks in Exhibit 28 below.** For TW investors, we recommend rotating into value/low vol exposure.

DETAILS

TAIWAN IS NOW THE MOST DOMINANT EXPOSURE IN REGIONAL BENCHMARKS/FUNDS

As of April end 2026, Taiwan is the biggest exposure in MSCI EM index, accounting for ~25% of the index (TSMC accounting for 14%) and in MSCI Asia ex Japan Index, accounting for 28.1% of the index (TSMC at 16%). In line with Taiwan's growing dominance in regional benchmarks, the allocation for Asia ex Japan Funds and Global Emerging market funds in Taiwan has seen a sharp increase over the last few years. Taiwan allocation is now at record high levels for Asian and GEM funds - Asia ex Japan funds on an average have 22.1% allocation to Taiwan vs. 21.9% for China, 19% for Korea and 9% for India. GEM funds, on an average have 22.3% allocation in TW, 20% in China, 17% in KR and 10% in India. YTD, Taiwan has seen foreign fund flow of 15.4bn USD, +26% yoy compared to the amount in same period in 2025 while domestic fund flow has been equally strong at 14.3bn USD. Overall foreign flow (institutional and retail), however is still negative at -3bn USD due to the extreme outflow seen in Mar (-29bn USD). However, since April, TW has seen the highest amount of foreign flow (16bn USD) in Asia, outside Japan (85bn USD). Given extreme inflow again, we expect foreign flow to slow down. (Exhibit 1-Exhibit 5)

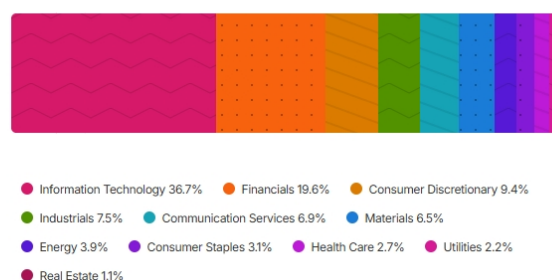
EXHIBIT 1: As of April end 2026, Taiwan is the biggest exposure in MSCI EM index, accounting for ~25% of the index with TSMC accounting for 14%

Weight for MSCI EM Index

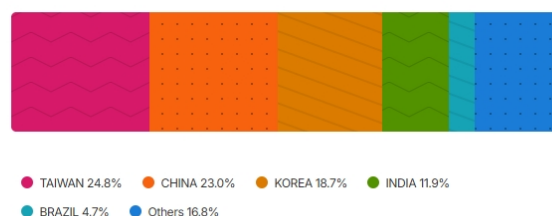
Top 10 constituents

TAIWAN SEMICONDUCTOR MFG	14.21%
SAMSUNG ELECTRONICS CO	6.03%
SK HYNIX	4.05%
TENCENT HOLDINGS LI (CN)	3.26%
ALIBABA GRP HLDG (HK)	2.37%
DELTA ELECTRONICS	1.14%
MEDIATEK INC	1.07%
CHINA CONSTRUCTION BK H	0.92%
HDFC BANK	0.79%
RELIANCE INDUSTRIES	0.79%

Sector weights



Country weights



30th April, 2026

Source: MSCI EM Index

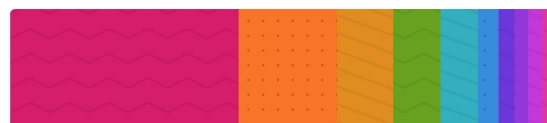
EXHIBIT 2: In MSCI Asia ex Japan Index, Taiwan now accounts for 28.1% of the index as of April 30th, 2026

MSCI Asia ex Japan Index

Top 10 constituents

TAIWAN SEMICONDUCTOR MFG	16.08%
SAMSUNG ELECTRONICS CO	6.82%
SK HYNIX	4.59%
TENCENT HOLDINGS LI (CN)	3.69%
ALIBABA GRP HLDG (HK)	2.68%
DELTA ELECTRONICS	1.29%
MEDIATEK INC	1.22%
AIA GROUP	1.10%
CHINA CONSTRUCTION BK H	1.04%
DBS GROUP HOLDINGS	0.95%

Sector weights

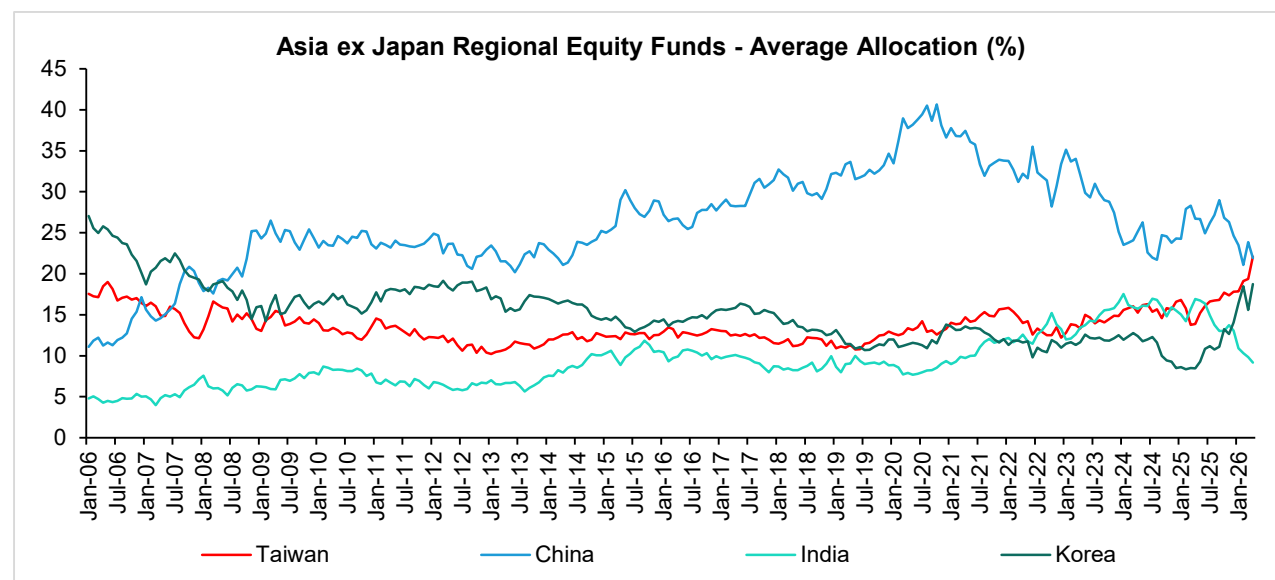


Country weights

April 30th, 2026

Source: MSCI Asia ex Japan Index

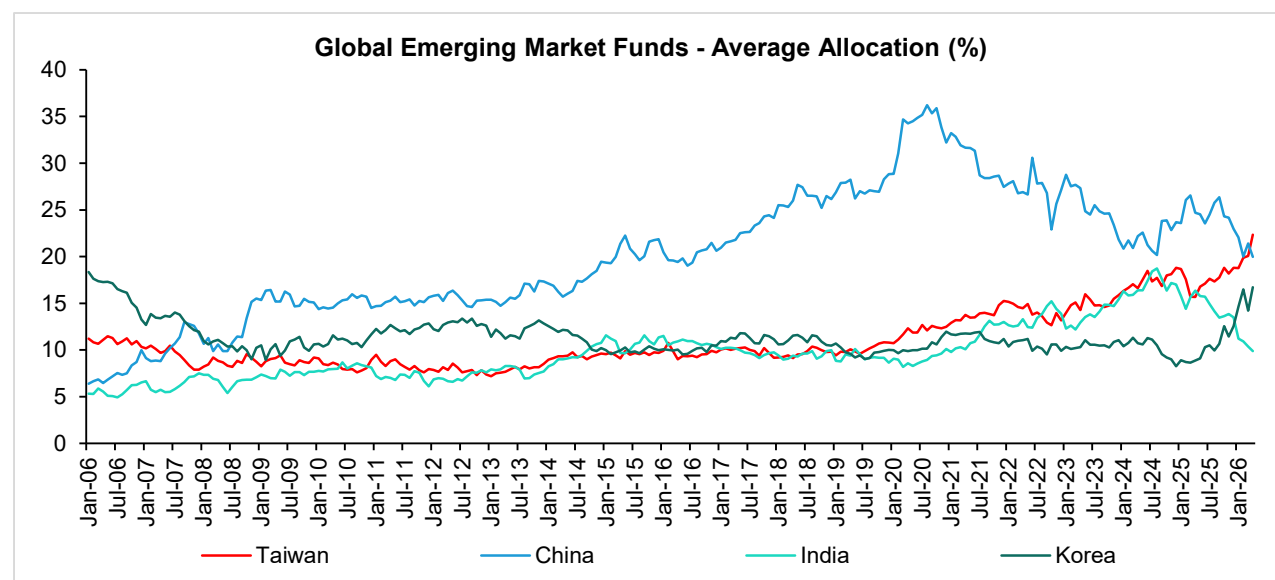
EXHIBIT 3: Asia ex Japan funds' allocation towards TW equities have seen a steady increase since 2025 with average allocation now at record high of 22.1%. Asian funds, on an average have 21.9% China, 19% Korea and 9% India



Data till Apr 30th 2026

Source: EPFR, Bernstein Analysis

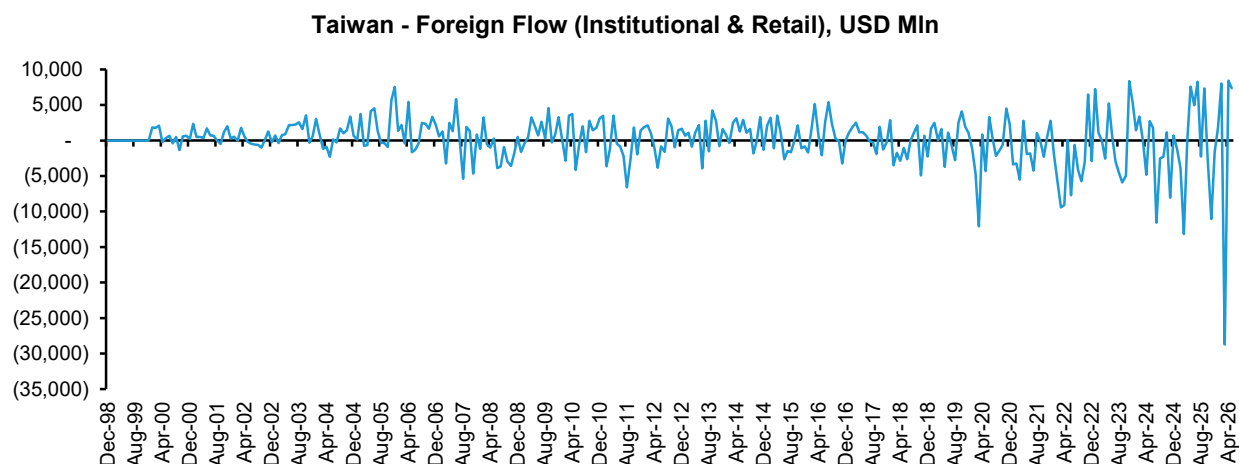
EXHIBIT 4: Global Emerging Market funds allocation to TW has seen a much sharper rise since 2019, now reaching record high of 22.3% vs. 20% in China, 17% in Korea and 10% in India



Data till Apr 30th 2026

Source: EPFR, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 5: YTD, Taiwan market has seen foreign outflow of -3bn USD due to extreme outflows seen in Mar (-29bn USD). However, since April, it is the only Asian market outside of Japan to see net inflows (Q226 inflows of 16bn USD). Given extreme inflow again, we expect foreign flow to slow down



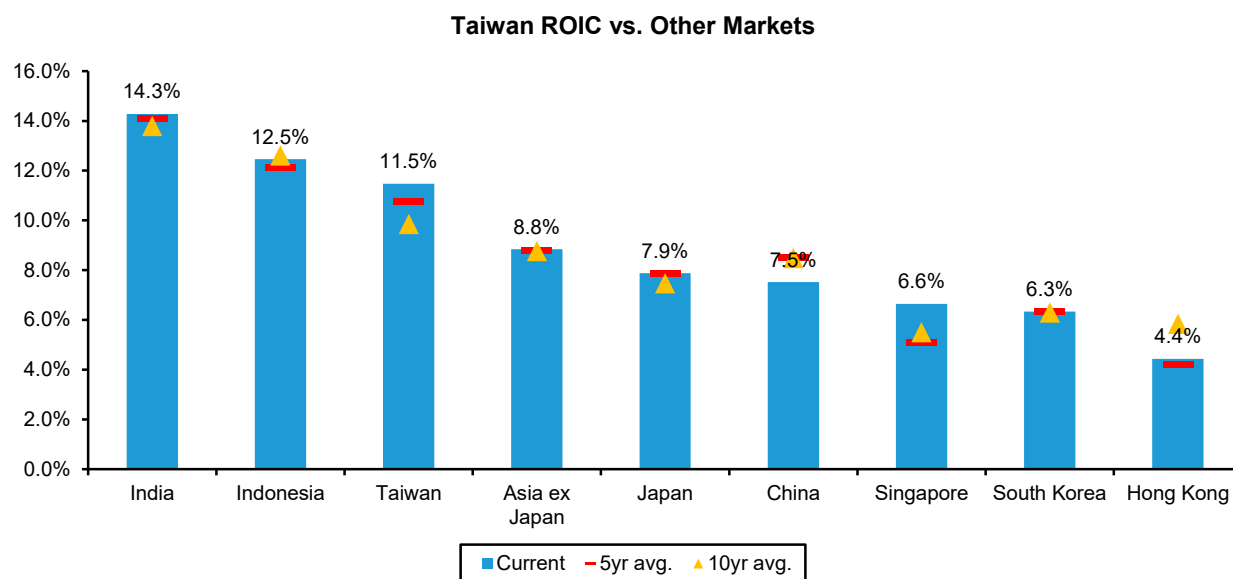
Data as of May 27th 2026

Source: Bloomberg, IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

TAIWAN - STRONG FUNDAMENTALS BUT ISN'T IT ALL PRICED-IN?

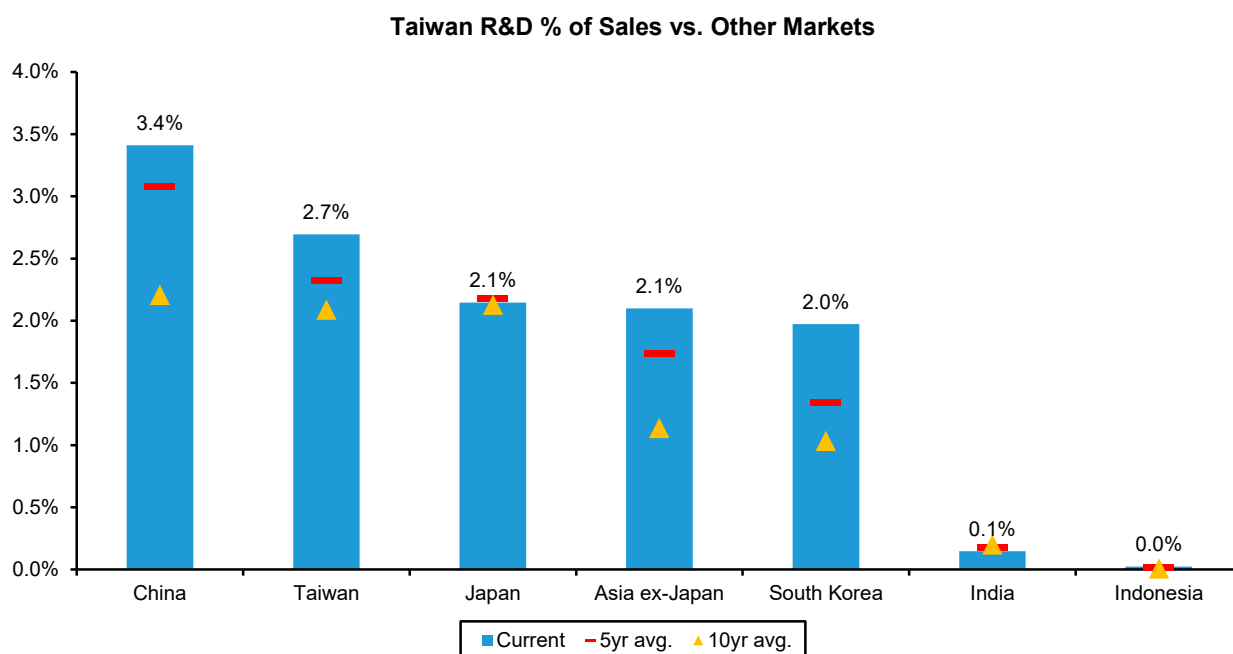
Taiwan has always been a high quality and high innovation market, and now it offers quite attractive growth opportunities for investors too. Taiwan has high ROIC of 11.5%, which indicate stronger return on invested capital than most of Asian peers (though still behind India/Indonesia) (Exhibit 6) ROIC of TW market has seen improvement compared to its 5yr/10yr average of 11%/10% respectively. Taiwan is also one of the leading innovation-driven economies in Asia, and along with China, it is now in the top tier of R&D intensive markets. Over the past ten year, the market has experienced a structural upgrade, and its R&D to sale ratio has grown steadily from 1.7% to 2.7% now.(Exhibit 7). One major change for Taiwan has come from the AI wave - given TW offers an extensive AI exposure for investors across Semis and Hardware, we now see Taiwan as the leading growth market in Asia with next 3yr earnings growth expectations of 29% while is the highest in the region. Interestingly, Taiwan and Korea are the only two Asian markets where future earnings expectations are higher than the average growth seen in the recent 5yrs. (Exhibit 8) Hence, fundamentally the market looks quite strong with high ROIC, high growth and high innovation exposure for investors.

EXHIBIT 6: Taiwan has better return on invested capital than most of Asian peers (except India/Indonesia) and higher than its own 5yr/10yr levels



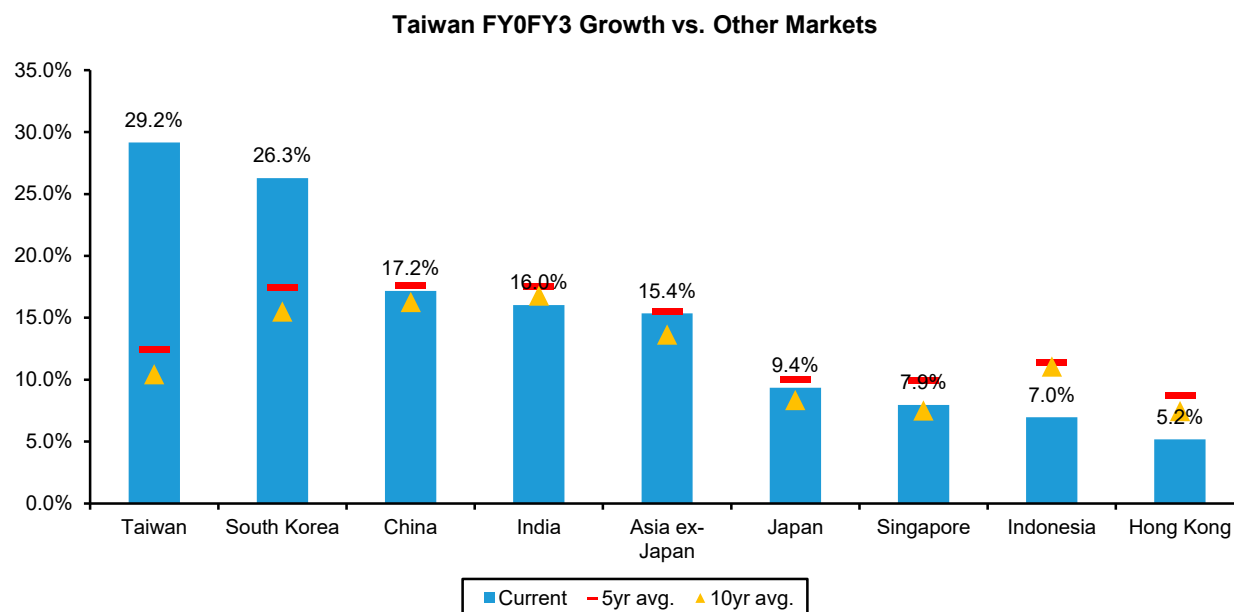
Data as of May 22th 2026. The chart shows median for each category
 Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: Taiwan ranks second in the region on innovation, behind China. Its R&D to sale ratio is above the historical averages, which reflects accelerating investment on innovation in the past few years



Data as of May 22th 2026. The chart shows median for each category
 Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

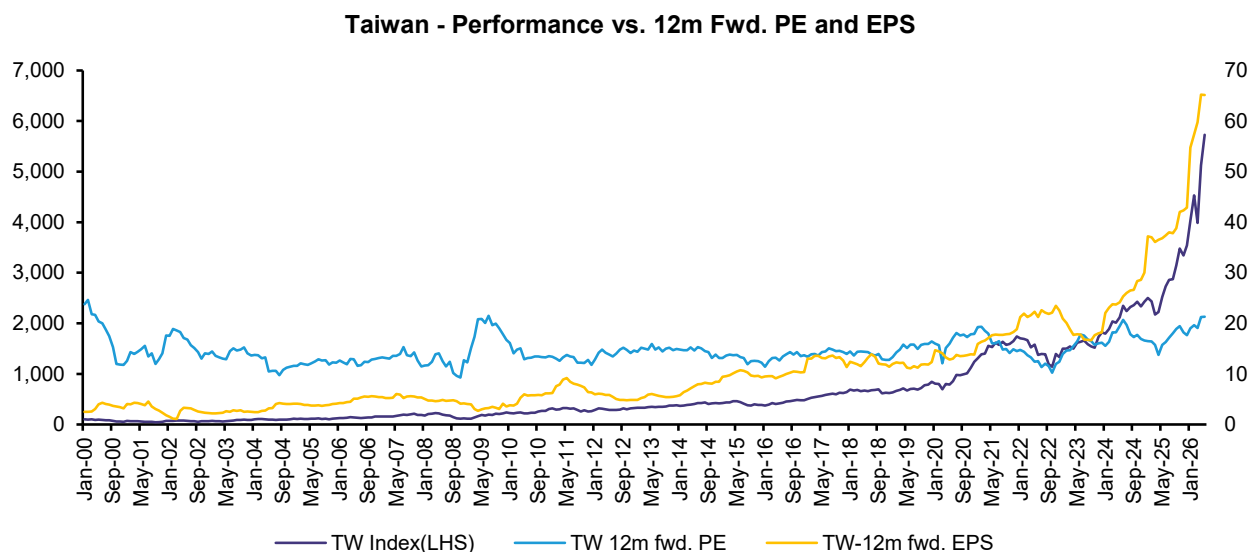
EXHIBIT 8: **Next 3yr earnings growth expectations is the highest for Taiwan markets. Interestingly, Taiwan and Korea are the only two Asian markets where future earnings expectations are higher than the average seen in the recent 5yrs**



Data as of May 22nd 2026. The chart show 3yr expected earnings CAGR
Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

Robust earnings upgrade cycle has supported the market rally, making it less of a bubble. We see that the market performance has been more driven by earnings than multiple expansion. Now that the earnings expectations are already near historical high, continued upward revisions look less sustainable. While upgrades have not shown clear peak yet, implying there is still some runway left; however risk of earnings expectations peaking is increasing. What further worries us is that all the fundamental strength and earnings growth seem to be priced in. In terms of PE multiples, Taiwan market is trading near record high, of 21x fwd. PE ie. +2.6SD above long-term average. On PB, we have never seen such multiples as Taiwan trades at 4.5x PB ie. +5.2SD above long-term average. Do note, Taiwan had much higher PE back in 2000 at around 25x. The equity risk premium in Taiwan has continued to decline since 2022, and it has reached record low levels. These record low risk premium levels look unsustainable, though it is difficult to foresee when the inflection might happen. (Exhibit 9-Exhibit 13)

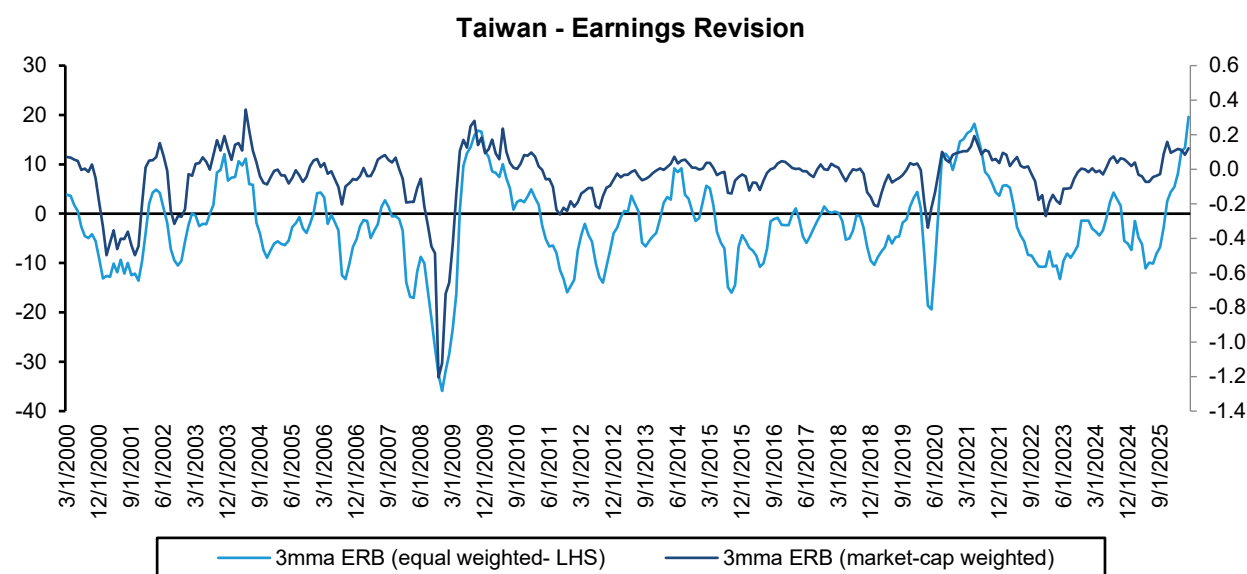
EXHIBIT 9: Taiwan rally has been more led by earnings than multiple-expansion, making it more healthy and less of a bubble



Price is for Taiwan broader in USD Terms. Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: MSCI, FactSet, Bloomberg, Bernstein Analysis

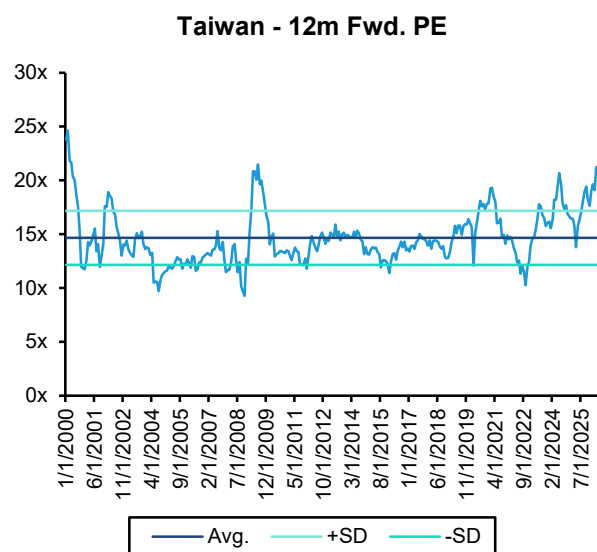
EXHIBIT 10: Taiwan has been in a strong upgrade cycle which has supported the market rally. However, now the earnings expectations are already near historical high, making continued upward revisions less sustainable



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

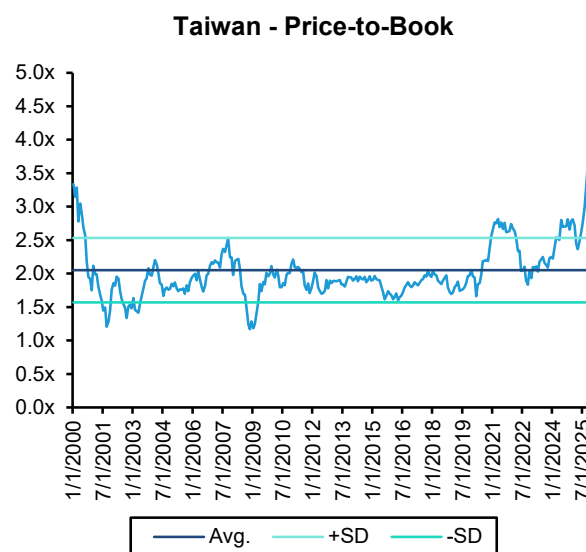
EXHIBIT 11: Taiwan is trading near record high valuations at 21x fwd. PE ie. +2.6SD above average



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

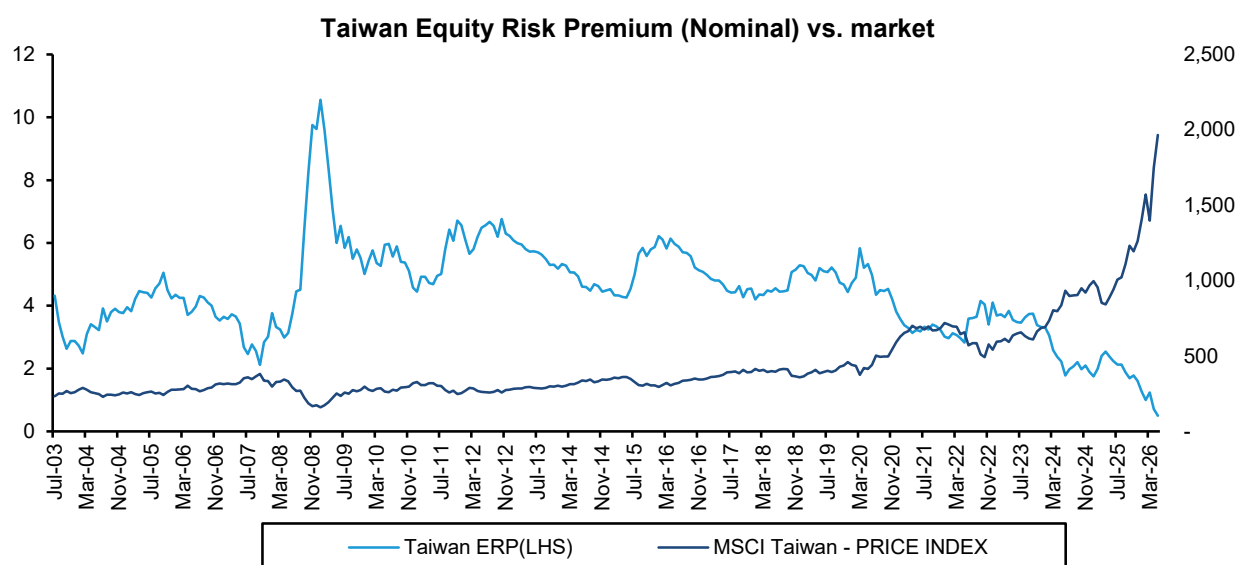
EXHIBIT 12: Taiwan is trading at never seen before PB multiples of 4.5x PB ie. +5.2SD above long-term average



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 13: The equity risk premium in Taiwan has continued to decline since 2022 and it has reached record low levels. While these are not sustainable levels, it is difficult to pin-point what would reverse this



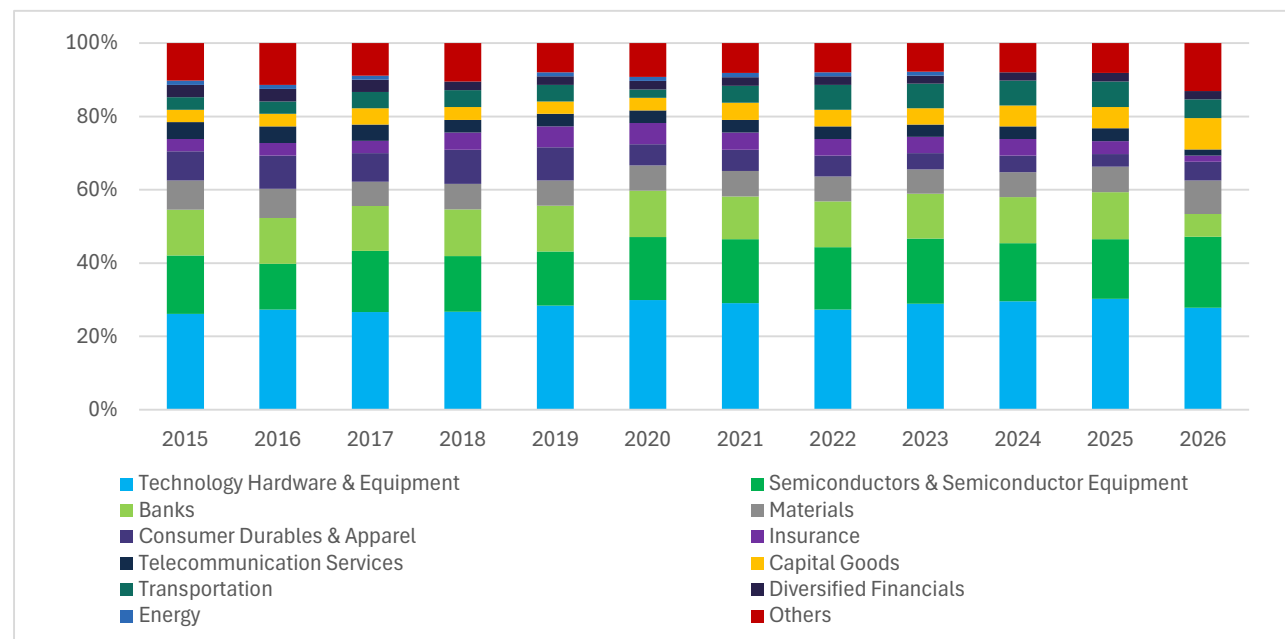
Data as of May 28th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

THE MARKET HAS NEVER BEEN SO CONCENTRATED

Technology Hardware & Equipment and Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment have always been the two dominant sectors in Taiwan and their concentration in the index has been increasing. Ten years back, the two sectors represented 42% of the market in terms of count and 50% in terms of market cap. However, now these two sectors make up 49% of the market in terms of count but 84% in terms of market-cap. Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment accounts for 62% of total market cap, followed by Technology Hardware & Equipment (22%). The other sectors with decent representation in the index are Banks, Materials, Transportation and Capital Goods with around 5-10 stocks. The concentration is further visible when we look at the top 5-10 names in Taiwan market - the top 10 names account for 72% of Taiwan market while the top 5 names make up 66% of the market. Both stock correlation and factor correlation in Taiwan is going up, but factor correlation is now at record high. This highlights that intra market dispersion is getting to extreme levels now. (Exhibit 14-Exhibit 17).

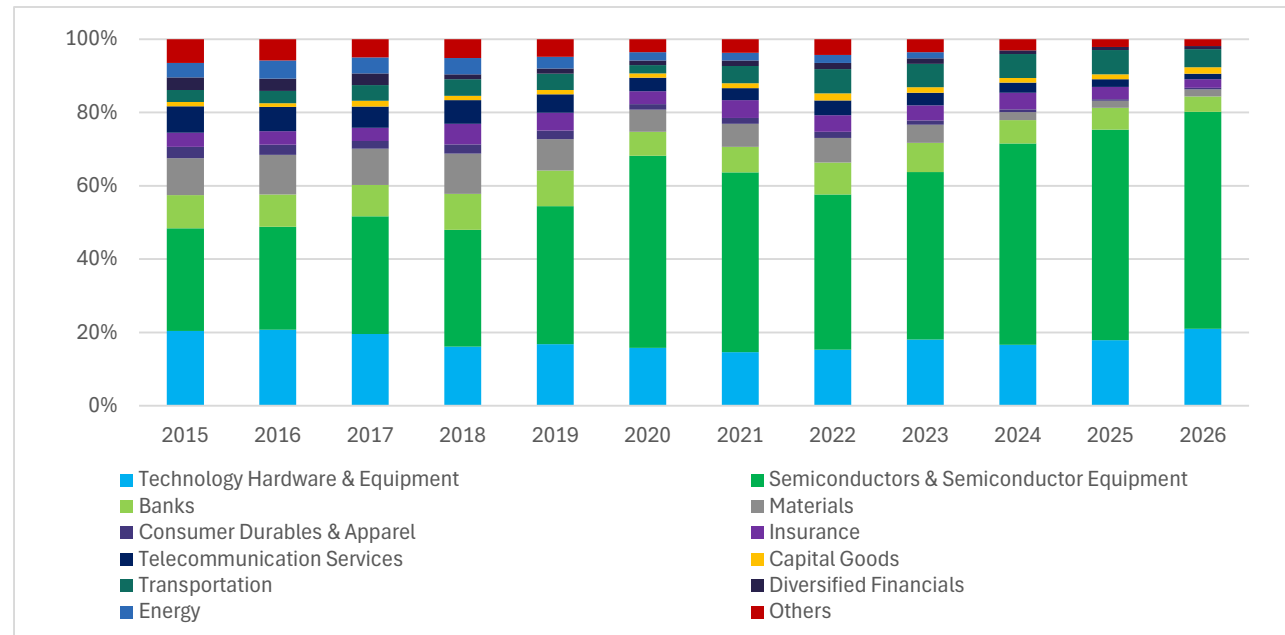
EXHIBIT 14: In terms of stock-count, Technology Hardware & Equipment stocks and Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment are the biggest sectors followed by Materials, Cap Goods and Banks



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

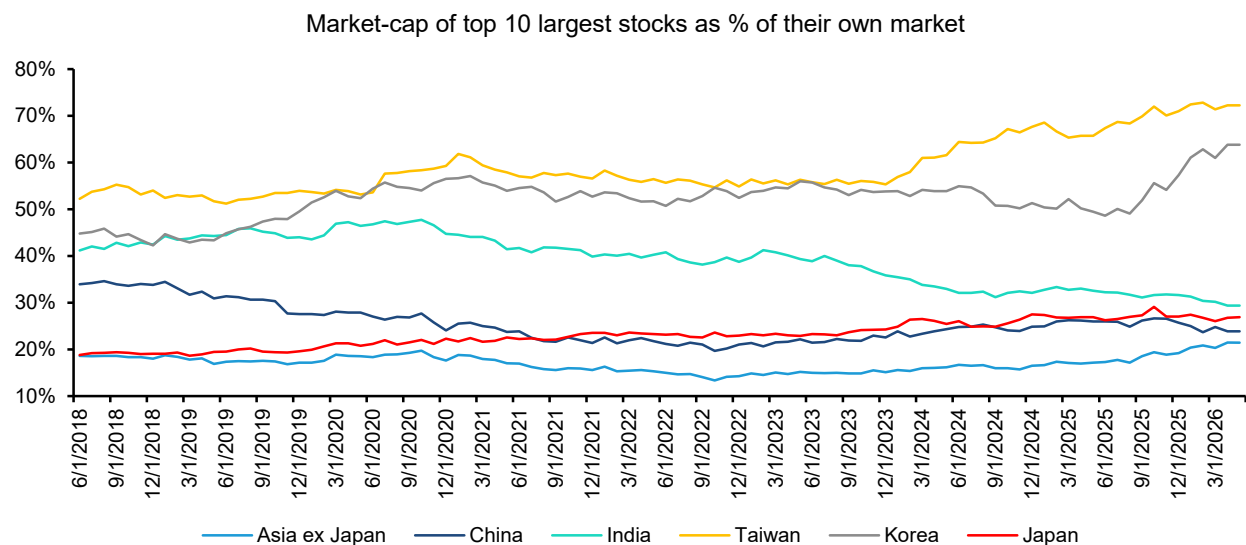
EXHIBIT 15: In terms of market cap, Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment accounts for 62% of total market cap, followed by Technology Hardware & Equipment (22%). 10yrs back, these two sectors accounted for 50% of the market. The rest of sectors only take single-digit participation in total market cap



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

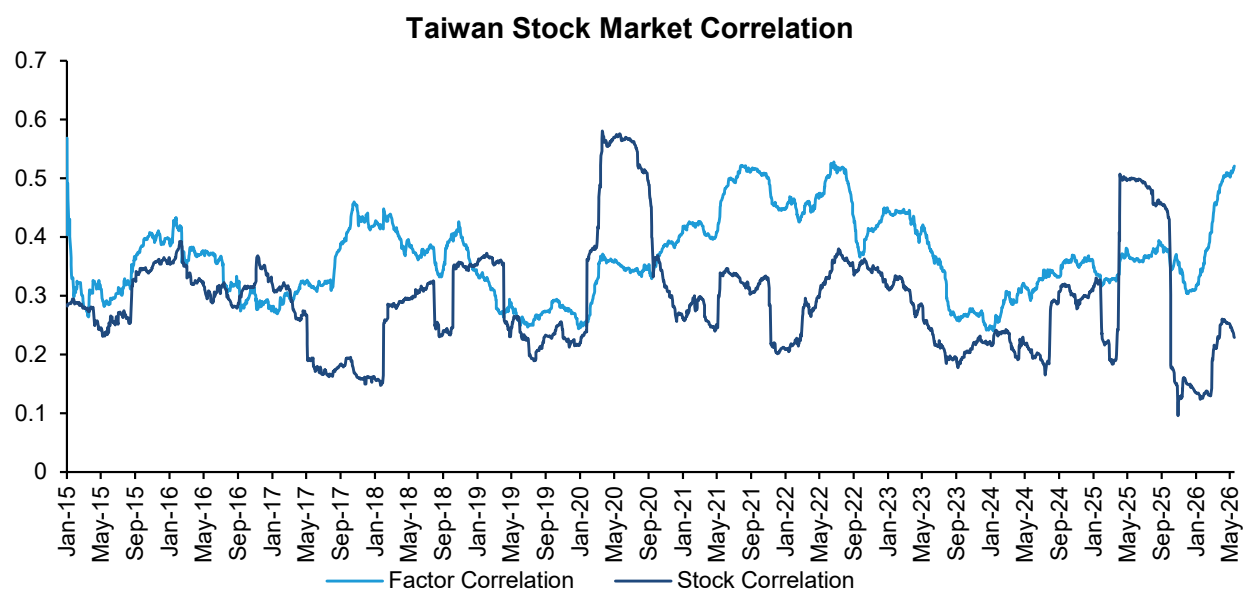
EXHIBIT 16: Concentration risk is the highest in Taiwan, where top 10 names account for 72% of their market's value. Similarly, Korean top 10 names accounted for 64% of the market value



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 17: **Both stock correlation and factor correlation in Taiwan is going up but factor correlation is now at record high. This highlights that intra market dispersion is getting to extreme levels now**



Data as of May 22th 2026

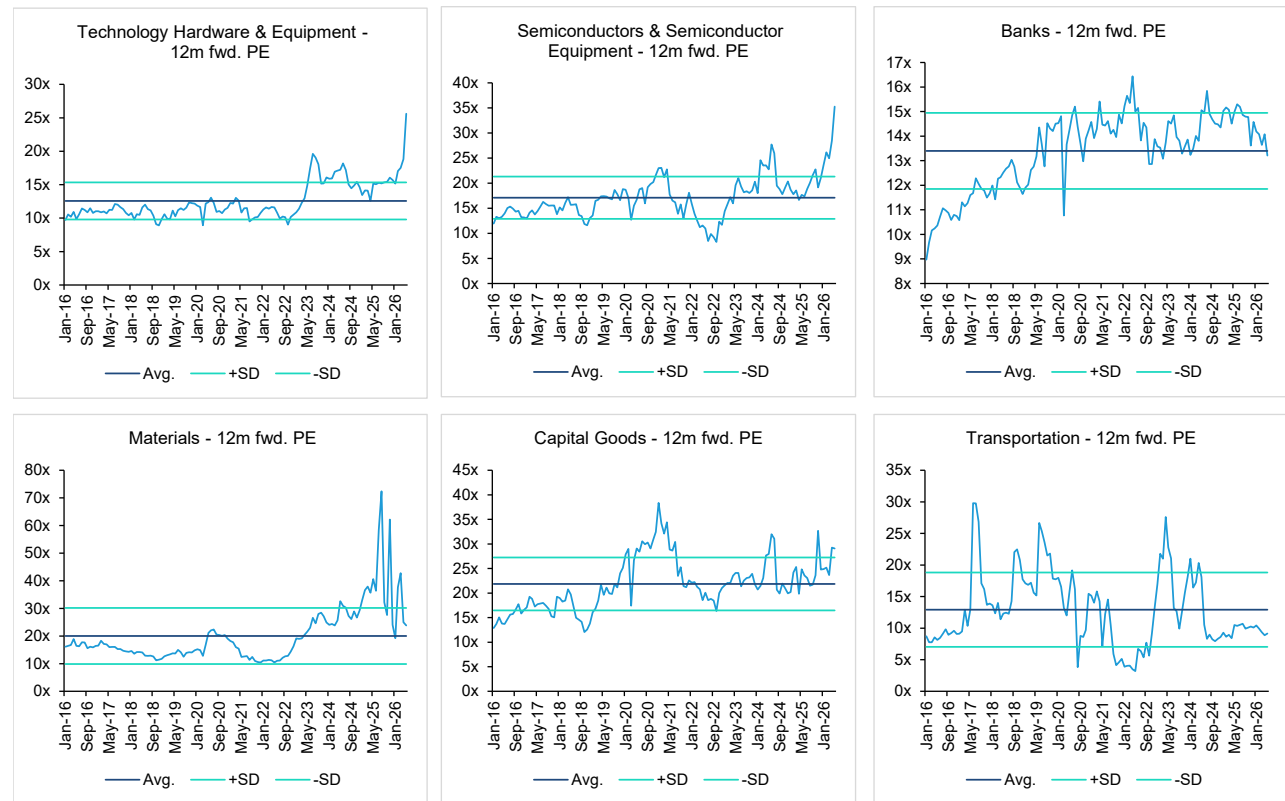
Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

SEMIS/TECH HARDWARE - ALREADY AT RECORD HIGH VALUATION AND EARNINGS

PE Valuation: Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment and Technology Hardware & Equipment are already trading at record high valuations. Semis is trading at 35x fwd. PE ie. +4.3SD above 10yr average, and Tech Hardware is priced at 26x fwd. PE ie. +4.7SD above 10yr average. Capital goods is a bit stretched too, trading at +1.3SD level, but all other sectors are still cheap. (Exhibit 18)

Earning Revision: Looking at the earning revision, the upgrade cycle for Technology Hardware & Equipment and Banks is already at record high, increasing the risk of peak earnings. Semis and Cap Goods have also been seeing rising upward revisions, though there is still more room for this to continue. Material and Transportation have already been in a moderating earnings revision cycle. Hence, further upward revisions could still support the Semis rally for some time, though the room for trends to continue looks narrower. (Exhibit 19)

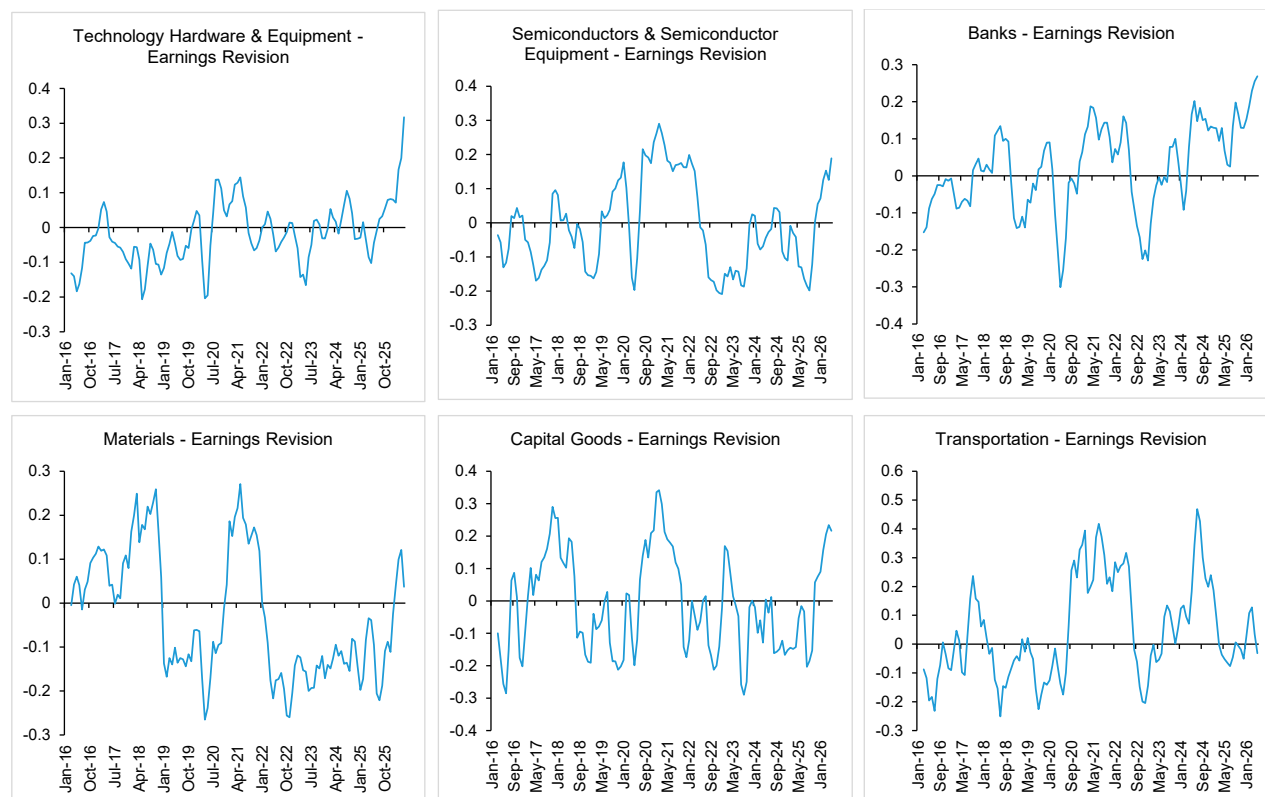
EXHIBIT 18: Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment and Technology Hardware & Equipment are trading at record high valuations. Even Capital goods is stretched, trading above +1SD, while other sectors are cheap



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 19: The upgrade cycle for Technology Hardware & Equipment and Banks is already at record high, increasing the risk of peak earnings. Semis and CapGoods have also been seeing rising upward revisions, though there is still more room for this to continue



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

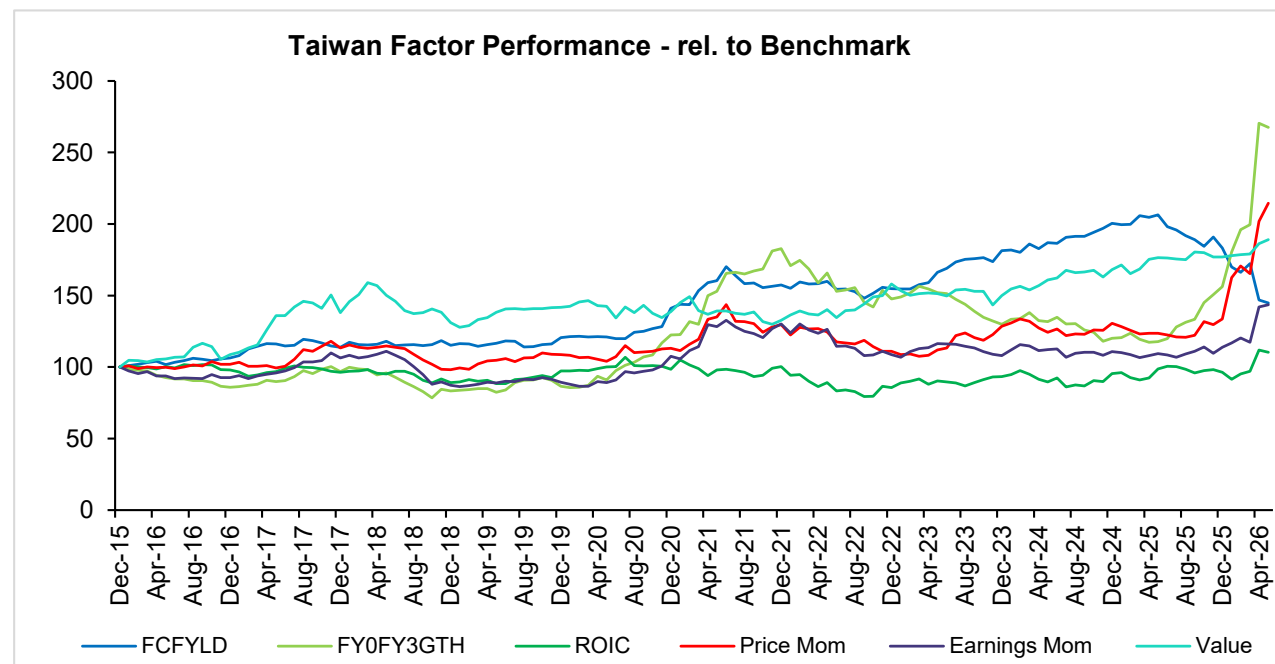
GROWTH & MOMENTUM AT EXTREME - RISK OF INFLECTION QUITE HIGH

Performance: Taiwan over the long-term has been a value/high yield play, however during tech/growth cycles, we see growth stocks outperforming sharply. Both High Yield and value were the best performing styles in Taiwan in 2023 and 2024, however growth and momentum styles saw a massive jump since Q425 and YTD, has outperformed the market by 71% to 61% respectively. Given the market itself is up more than 50%, growth and momentum investors YTD have made more than 100% returns in Taiwan. High yield/value on the other hand are down -21%/-20% relative to the market. Exhibit 20

Valuation, earning revision and crowding: Momentum and Quality are the most expensive styles in Taiwan, trading at decade high valuations. Growth portfolio is also expensive, though still below record peak seen in 2020/2024. Price momentum and earnings momentum are valued at 34x/30x fwd. PE, both around +5SD above the ten-year average, and quality is now +3SD above the ten-year average. Growth stocks have re-rated to 35x fwd. PE ie. +2SD above the ten-year average. Value/High Yield is trading near average valuations. Given there has been a broad-based re-rating cycle, we look at relative valuations - even then, momentum and quality is trading at record high levels while growth is just shy of 2020 peak. Earnings has been a strong catalyst and momentum/quality/growth are all at record high earnings expectations - this is becoming vulnerable to peak in upgrade cycle. Value/high yield have more room for upward revisions to continue. Relative to market, upward revisions for price momentum portfolio has already peaked while growth/quality/earnings momentum are at record high. Interestingly, earnings sentiment for value/high yield is now near decade high bearishness. Growth is overcrowded while crowding risk in momentum/quality is still not that extreme yet. Value/high yield have fallen to decade low crowding levels. Just to highlight - Materials, Semi, Tech Hardware are the key growth sectors while momentum is all about Semis and Tech Hardware. Value sits in Banks, Transportation and Materials(Exhibit 21-Exhibit 26). Because of the extreme momentum trends, the intra market/ factor dispersion is at record high - momentum is all about growth stocks in Taiwan while value/low vol is sitting at 10 year high laggard position. However, when looking at earnings momentum correlation with other styles, the factor dispersion is still not at

decade high. (Exhibit 27)

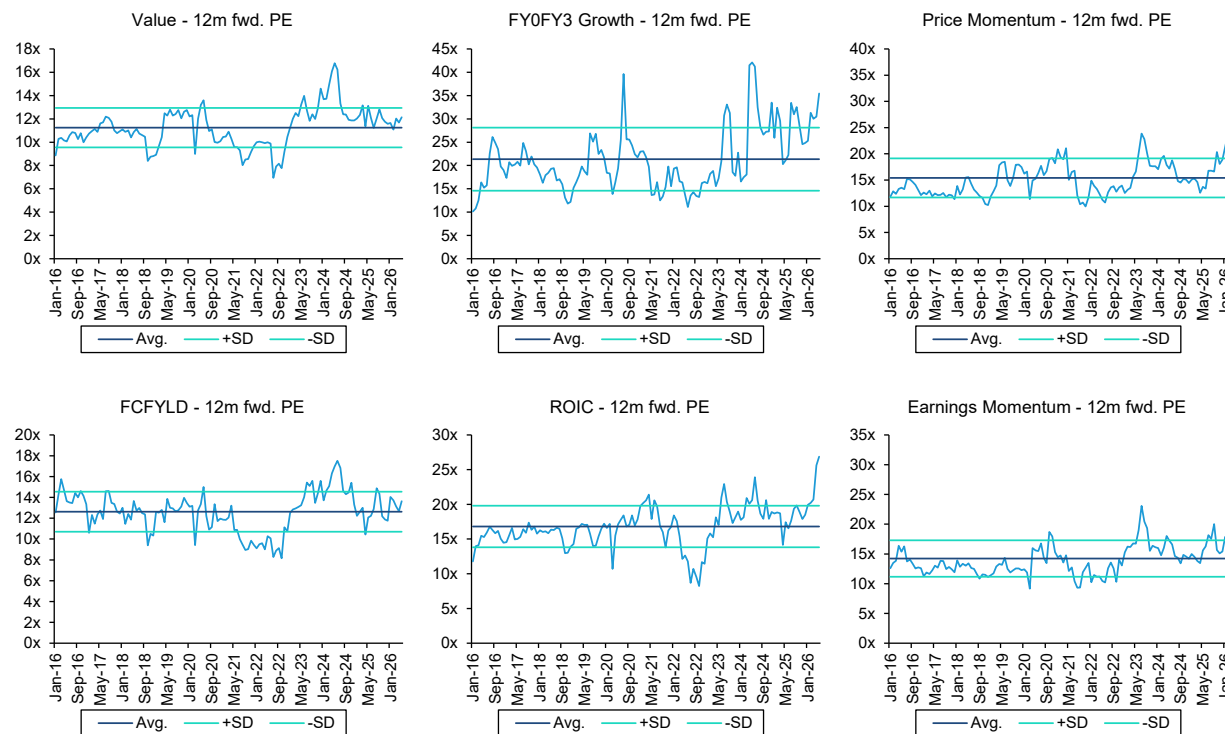
EXHIBIT 20: High yield and value stocks the best performers in Taiwan in the past three years, while in YTD, growth and momentum have outperformed them both



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

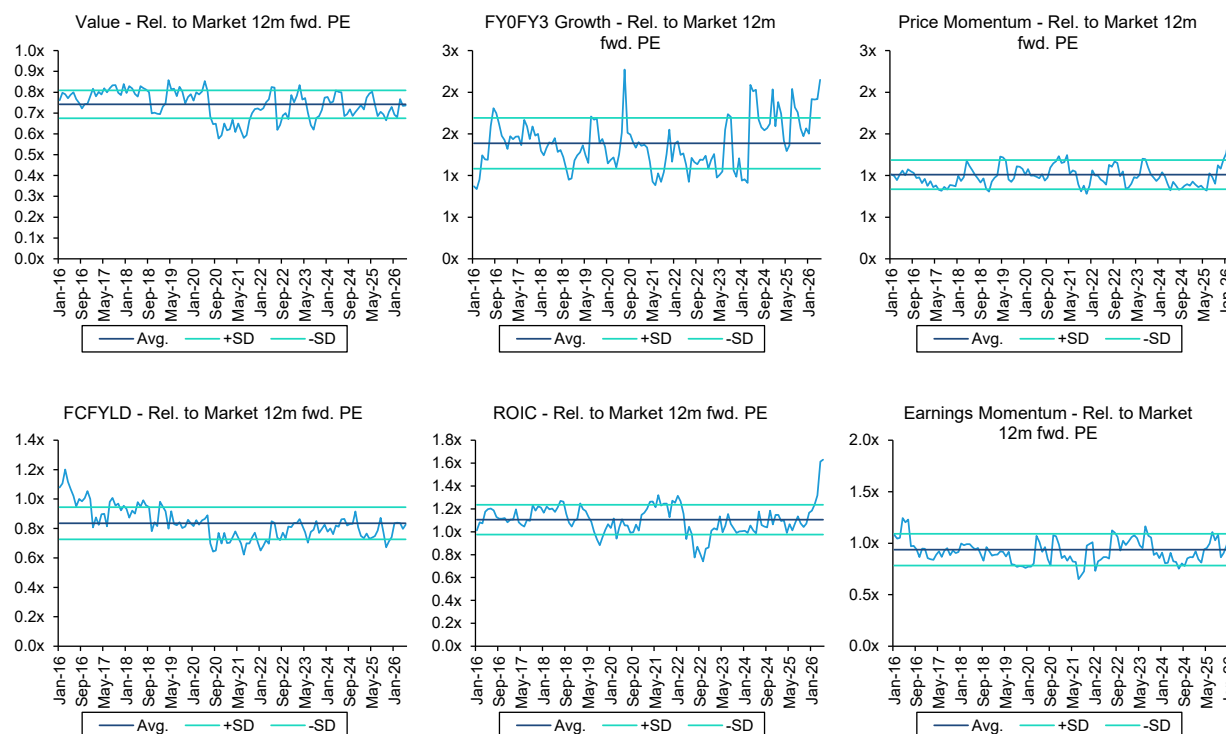
EXHIBIT 21: Momentum and Quality are the most expensive styles in Taiwan, trading at decade high valuations. Growth portfolio is also expensive, though still below record peak seen in 2020/2024. Value/High Yield is trading near average valuations



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

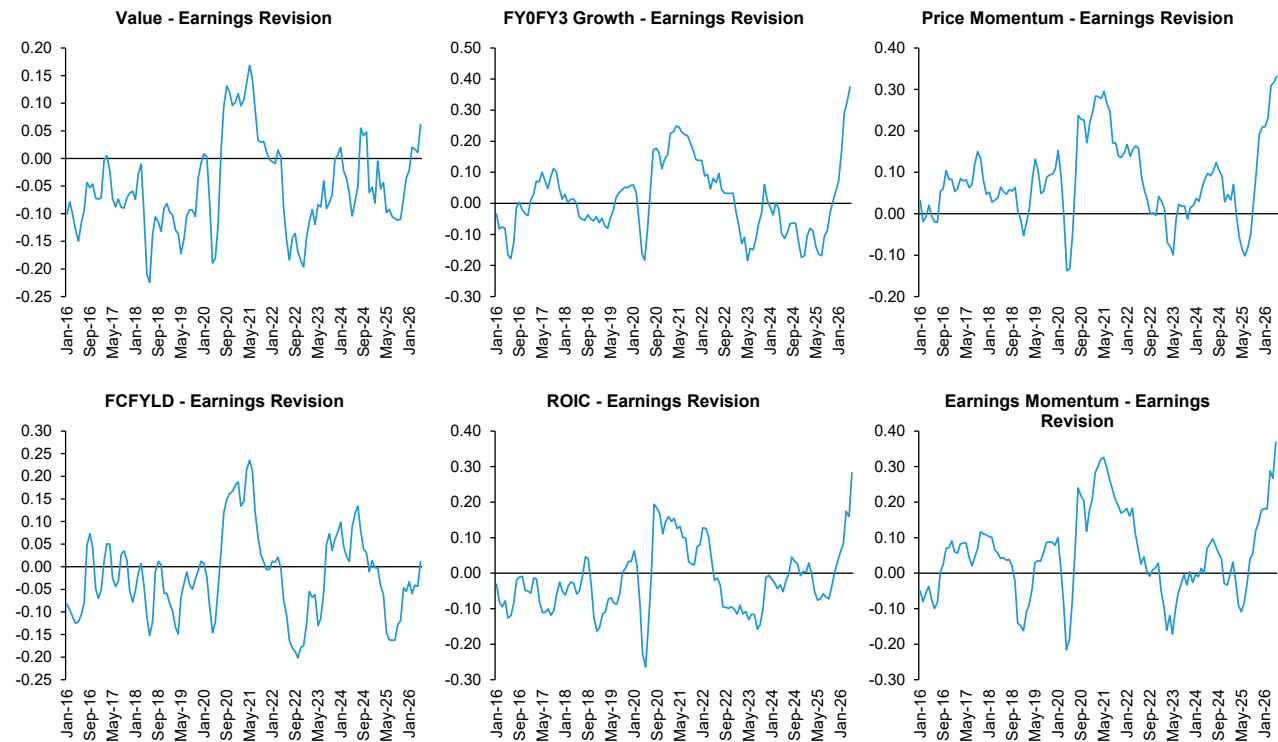
EXHIBIT 22: Given there has been a broad-based re-rating cycle, we look at relative valuations - even then, momentum and quality is trading at record high levels while growth is just shy of 2020 peak



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

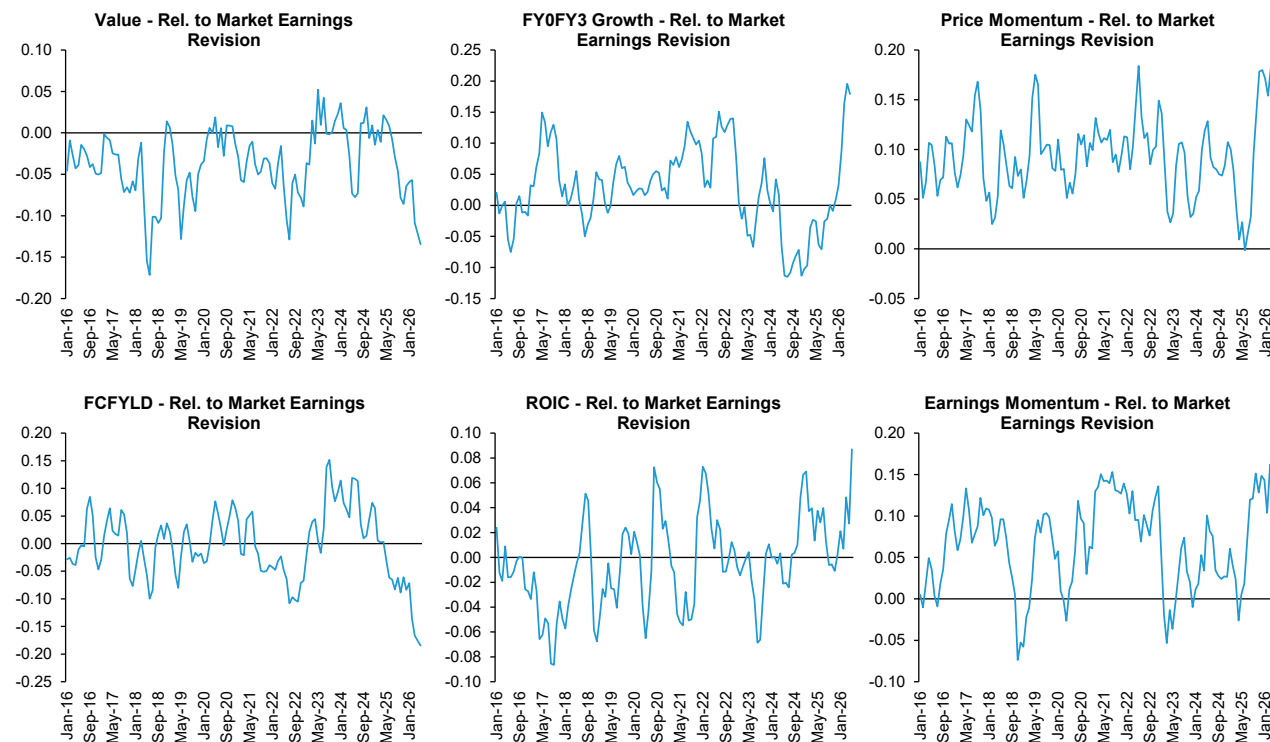
EXHIBIT 23: Earnings has been a strong catalyst and momentum/quality/growth are all at record high earnings expectations - this is showing vulnerability from potential peak in upgrade cycle. Value/high yield have more room for upward revisions to continue



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

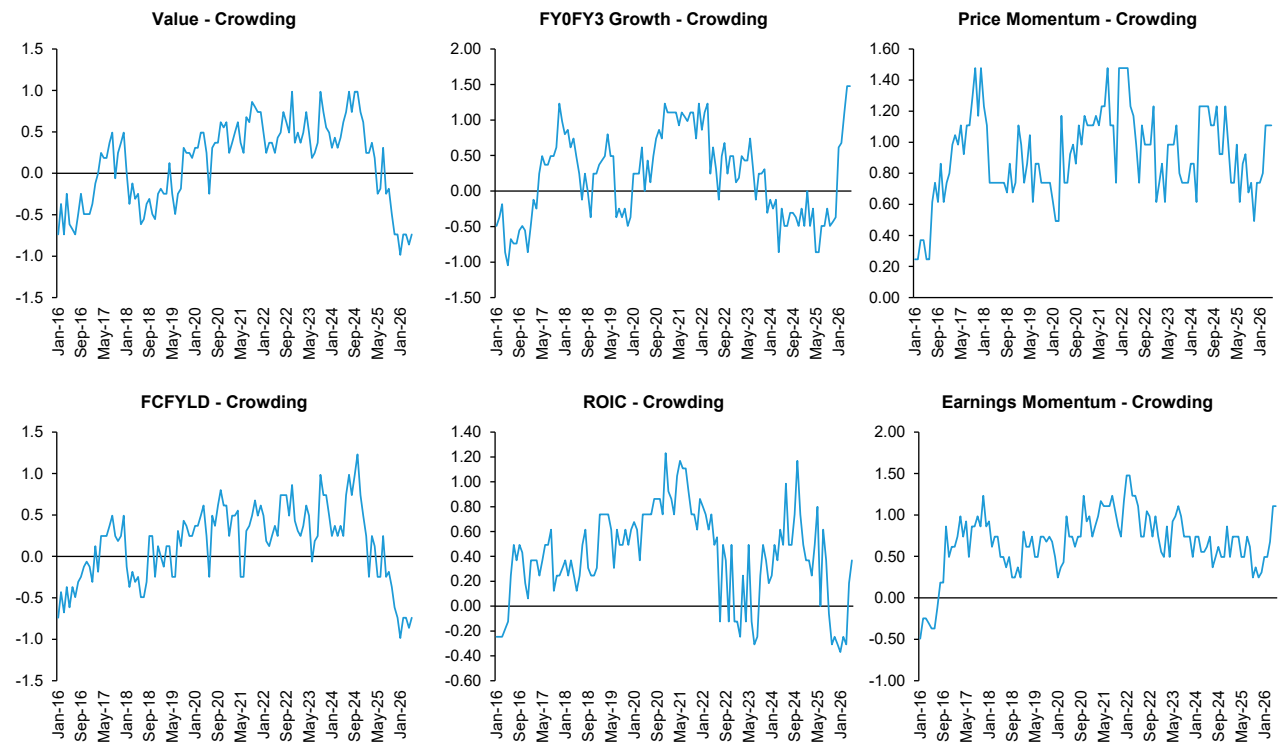
EXHIBIT 24: Relative to market, upward revisions for price momentum portfolio has already peaked while growth/quality/earnings momentum are at record high. Interestingly, earnings sentiment for value/high yield is now near decade high bearishness



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

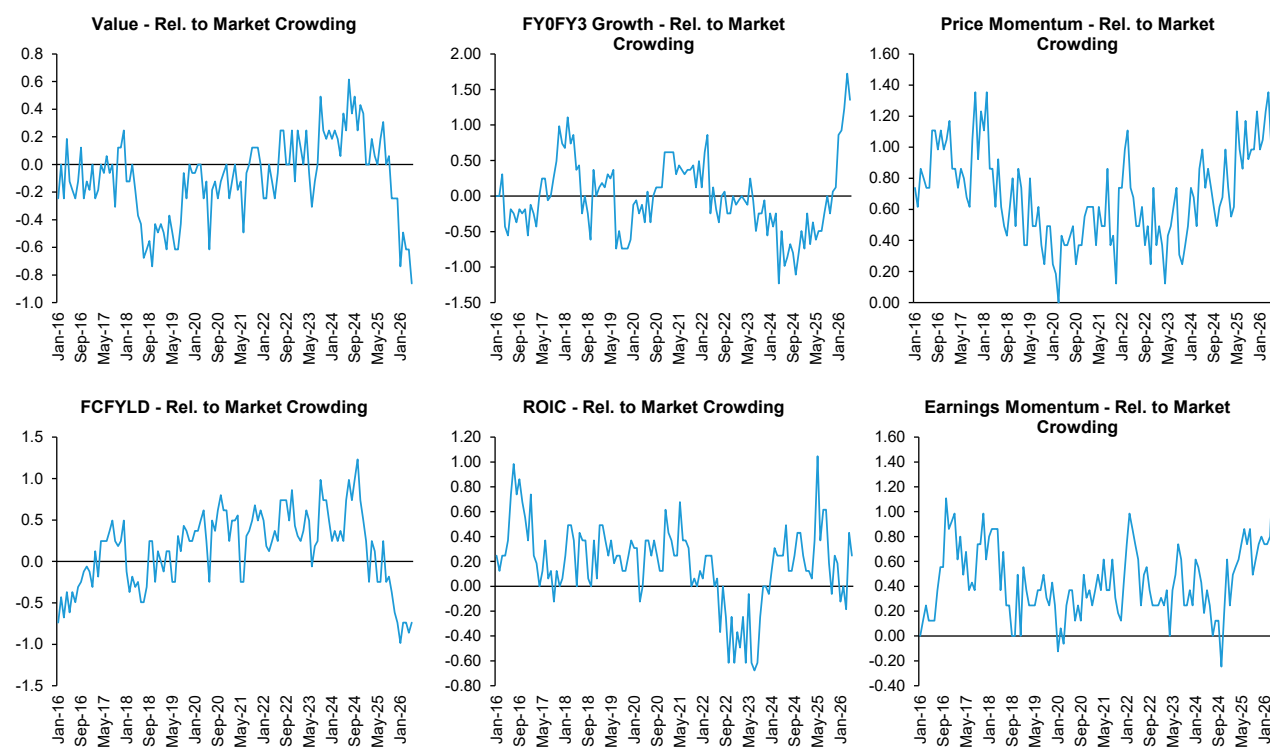
EXHIBIT 25: Growth is overcrowded while crowding risk in momentum/quality is still not that extreme yet. Value/high yield have fallen to decade low crowding levels



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

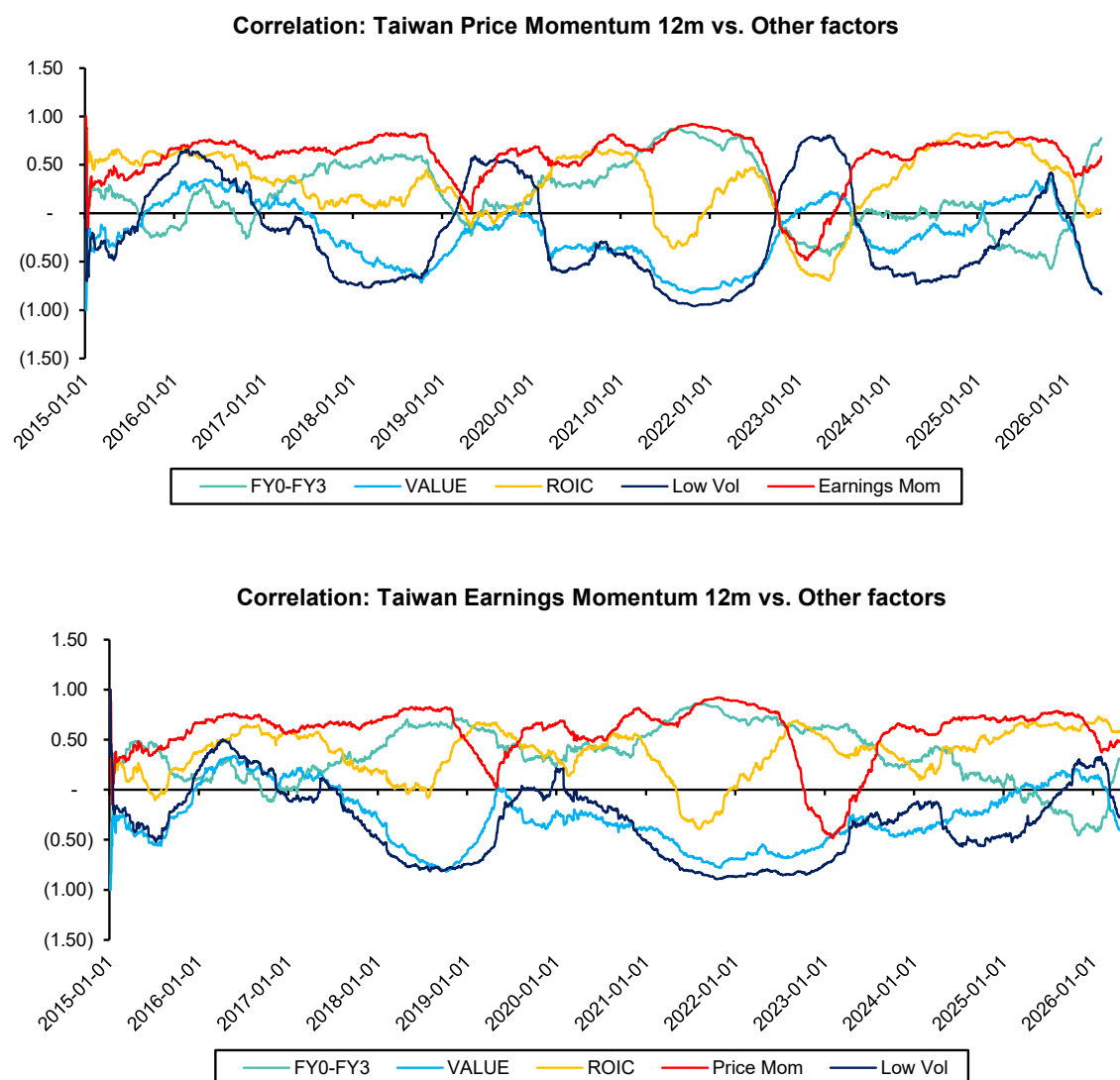
EXHIBIT 26: Relative to market, however, growth and momentum have been cooling down from the record crowding level while value/high yield seem to be bottoming out from historical low crowding levels



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 27: Dispersion between growth and value/low vol is at decade high in TW, though there is more room for trends to continue led by earnings momentum



Data as of May 22th 2026

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 28: **Taiwan high momentum and high growth stocks which are most vulnerable**

SEDOL	Sector	Company	12m Fwd. PE	10yr PE zscore	6m EPS Momentum	12m EPS Momentum	Crowding Decile (1=Most Crowded, 10=Least Crowded)	Bernstein Rating
637248	Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment	MEDIATEK INC	59x	7.1	-5%	-17%	3	O
626073	Technology Hardware & Equipment	DELTA ELECTRONICS	50x	4.8	61%	107%	2	O
613772	Technology Hardware & Equipment	UNIMICRON TECHNOLOGY	68x	1.1	300%	113%	2	O
662158	Materials	NAN YA PLASTIC	16x	-0.4	1965%	462%	1	
BFXZDY	Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment	ASE TECHNOLOGY HOLDING	34x	4.7	90%	54%	1	
B05638	Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment	GLOBAL UNICHIP CORP	111x	5.6	57%	42%	2	
B3FJBY	Semiconductors & Semiconductor Equipment	JENTECH PRECISION INDL	61x	4.5	75%	0%		
600521	Technology Hardware & Equipment	ACCTON TECHNOLOGY CORP	34x	2.9	47%	82%	3	
654489	Technology Hardware & Equipment	ASIA VITAL COMPONENTS	27x	-0.9	91%	157%	2	
631612	Technology Hardware & Equipment	ELITE MATERIAL CO	57x	6.8	98%	90%		
B734XQ	Technology Hardware & Equipment	ZHEN DING TECHNOLOGY	42x	8.8	34%	17%	3	

Data as of May 22th 2026. Analyst Ratings: O= Outperform, M=Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand)/N=Neutral (Autonomous Brand), U = Underperform rating. Further details of the research and important disclosures on the above covered securities are available on the Bernstein Research website: <https://bernsteinautonomous.bluematrix.com/sellside/ Disclosures.action>

Source: IBES, MSCI, FactSet, Bernstein analysis

We acknowledge the contributions of Rui Shi to this report

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

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